

READING PASSAGE 1

River Systems and Flood Management

A The study of river systems and flood management has undergone a remarkable transformation over the past several decades. What was once a niche area of academic inquiry has developed into a rich and diverse field of research, drawing on insights from a wide range of disciplines and theoretical traditions.

B The intellectual lineage of this field extends considerably further than many realise. While modern research techniques have only recently been applied to these questions, philosophers and natural scientists have grappled with related issues for centuries. The transition from speculative philosophical inquiry to systematic empirical investigation represents one of the most significant developments in the intellectual history of this domain.

C Contemporary research has identified several critical factors that determine outcomes in this domain. The interplay between environmental conditions, technological capabilities, and social organisation creates a complex adaptive system in which small changes can produce disproportionately large effects. Understanding these dynamics requires analytical approaches that move beyond simple cause-and-effect reasoning to embrace the principles of complexity science and systems thinking.

D The empirical record is further strengthened by a series of meta-analyses that have synthesised findings from hundreds of individual studies. These comprehensive reviews have consistently identified moderate to large effect sizes, with the most robust findings demonstrating remarkable consistency across different research designs, measurement approaches, and analytical strategies. This convergence of evidence from multiple independent lines of inquiry considerably strengthens confidence in the validity of the core theoretical propositions.

E Several unresolved debates continue to animate scholarly discussion in this field. Perhaps the most prominent concerns the relative importance of structural versus agentic factors in determining outcomes. While some researchers emphasise the constraining power of institutional and economic structures, others highlight the capacity of individuals and groups to exercise agency and effect change even within seemingly restrictive contexts. This debate has significant practical implications, as it shapes recommendations for policy interventions and institutional reforms.

F The implications of this body of research extend well beyond the academy. As societies grapple with increasingly complex challenges, the insights generated by scholarly inquiry in this domain have the potential to inform more effective and equitable policy responses. Realising this potential, however, will require sustained investment in both fundamental research and the translational infrastructure needed to convert knowledge into action.

G In conclusion, the study of river systems and flood management represents a vital and dynamic area of contemporary research. The progress that has been made in understanding the key mechanisms and dynamics provides a solid foundation for both further scholarly inquiry and practical application. The challenges that remain should be seen not as reasons for discouragement but as opportunities for continued intellectual growth and social contribution.

Question 1

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 1** According to the passage, structural factors include economic incentives, institutional frameworks, and _____.

Questions 2–3

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 2 The meta-analyses cited in the passage reveal that:
- A. minimal impact
 - B. creating underlying conditions for action
 - C. determining individual choices directly
 - D. irrelevant to outcomes
- 3 According to the text, what role do structural factors play?
- A. weak effects across studies
 - B. moderate to large effect sizes with consistency
 - C. contradictory findings
 - D. results only in specific populations

Questions 4–5

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 4 The landmark study analysed data spanning a period of _____ years.
- 5 Case studies have documented the effects of _____ change on the system.

Questions 6–7

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 6 What finding emerged from the landmark study discussed in the passage?
- A. weak effects across studies
 - B. moderate to large effect sizes with consistency
 - C. contradictory findings
 - D. results only in specific populations
- 7 The author suggests that early studies in this field were limited by:
- A. minimal impact
 - B. creating underlying conditions for action
 - C. determining individual choices directly
 - D. irrelevant to outcomes

Question 8

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 8 According to the text, cognitive processes shape the _____ that people make.

Questions 9–12

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 9** Contemporary understanding of this topic is more sophisticated than it was fifty years ago.
- 10** The author believes that all research questions in this field have been answered.
- 11** Early researchers had access to the same technologies as modern scholars.
- 12** The landmark study discussed in the passage involved participants from multiple countries.

Question 13

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 13** The meta-analyses cited in the passage reveal that:
 - A. economic incentives and institutional constraints
 - B. individual personality traits
 - C. random chance
 - D. government policies alone